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Perceptions: From Regard to Disdain

A place to begin thinking about why India and China are not friends is their perceptions of each other. For a brief moment in the mid-1950s, the two countries seemed to celebrate each other in the slogan 'Hindi-Chini bhai bhai'. Since then, the tone has been more sober, at the best of times. In the worst of times, it has been harsh. The Himalaya limited India–China interactions, especially between the centres of political, social, and economic power, but Buddhism and trade above all brought them into contact. From the fourth to the eleventh centuries CE, it is fair to say that China looked to India culturally as a result of the spread of Buddhism. From the eleventh century CE to about the fifteenth century CE, the relationship was reversed: parts of India paid material and political tribute to the Chinese court. During the colonial period, their perceptions were filtered through the views of the imperial powers and the experience of subjugation, and in the late nineteenth century Chinese perceptions of India turned negative. India's perceptions of China also turned negative, most bitterly after 1962. Contemporary images of each other in many walks of life, in the media, in popular culture, and in surveys are mixed, but negative, even racist perceptions abound. In addition, the two societies hold to a set of broad frameworks within which they cast themselves and their place in world history. These worldviews are not explicitly about India–China relations, but they have implications for how they perceive each other.